

## ***Book Review***

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**Jay Heinrichs. *Thank You for Arguing: What Aristotle, Lincoln, and Homer Simpson Can Teach Us about the Art of Persuasion*. New York: Three Rivers Press. 2007. \$13.95 paperback. ISBN 978-0-307-34144-0. p. xiii – 316.**

An engaging and often fun read, *Thank You for Arguing* attempts to strike a balance between contemporary examples and classical rhetorical concepts. Author Jay Heinrichs draws from experiences in his daily life with which most of his readers can relate—arguments with his wife, children and employers—as well as from history and popular culture. Thankfully, we found no tired repetition of the old “Socrates is a man” syllogism in the book.

Heinrichs successfully updates the study of rhetoric and argumentation while maintaining strong links to classical concepts and taxonomy. Heinrichs is at home discussing Brad Pitt and *South Park*, while easily integrating classical ideas and traditional concepts such as *phronesis*, *kairos* and *prosopopoeia*.

*Thank You for Arguing* is arranged into four main themes: offense, defense, advanced offense and advanced agreement. The first section—argumentative offense—is clearly Heinrichs’ primary interest, and comprises nearly half the book. Heinrichs introduces his readers to simple but effective argumentative techniques such as controlling the tense of the argument, focusing on future-oriented deliberative questions rather than forensic questions of blame or epideictic concern with value. Heinrichs’ distinctions are heavily influenced by Aristotelian conceptions of rhetoric and he does a fair job of imparting practical instruction in argumentation. Heinrichs’ chapters on defense are primarily dedicated to issues of identification of fallacies—including violations of argumentative etiquette—assessing ethos, and

practical wisdom. Heinrichs' section on "advanced offense" emphasizes identification through language choice and style, kairos and the selection of the appropriate argumentation medium. The final section titled "advanced agreement" is dedicated to timing and selecting the right argumentative tool for the argumentative job. Heinrich concludes with a chapter that reflects on the importance of rhetoric and argumentation in a democratic society.

Perhaps the most interesting feature of the book is Heinrichs' insertion of various items of interest in textboxes on the margins of the primary text. He identifies in the textboxes several different types of information including what he calls "argument tools" such as sympathy, stance, and the dogged question, notes useful figures of speech and a whole menu of "try this" selections such as "try this at home" and "try this with the boss." All are practical suggestions for applying the techniques he describes. Finally, he includes in the textboxes what he calls "persuasion alerts" where he points out various argumentative and persuasive strategies he has used in the text. These textboxes not only appeal to short-attention spanned readers but encourage readers to reflect upon Heinrichs' position, to recognize arguments where they might not have known to look for them, and to consider how they might apply some of these ideas in their own lives.

Heinrichs includes a few useful appendices. The first is simply called "The Tools" and is an outline and user-friendly guide to the 136 different tools of argument he identifies in textboxes throughout the text. Additional appendices include a glossary, a timeline of rhetoric and argumentation, and a list for further reading.

*Thank You for Arguing* presents scholars of argumentation and rhetoric with an interesting dilemma. The term "rhetoric" in popular discourse still sounds a negative note and conveying rhetoric as the antithesis of substantive inquiry and action. We are eager to support efforts to reorient public understanding of rhetoric as more than a system of artifice and inflated language; a system which forestalls and impedes rather than encourages action. Heinrichs' praise of rhetoric is a strong

effort to re-establish and restore rhetoric as one of the virtues of a free and democratic society. His effort, however, also calls forth a Platonic condemnation.

It is, of course, a matter of debate as to whether or not Plato's criticisms of the sophists were fair or accurate. Certainly much scholarship in recent years (e.g., the extensive work by Takis Poulakis) has vindicated the sophists. One might wonder, however, if Plato would not have called such efforts "a boorish sort of wisdom" as he called those who argued relative to whether or not the girl Oreithyia was indeed stolen by Boreas, the god of the north wind, or merely blown off the high rocks by a gust of wind. What mattered to Plato was not the historicity of the myth but the truth of the tale. Plato's issue with the sophists is not whether or not Gorgias, Protagoras and Hippias actually practiced the ignoble form of rhetoric he condemned. The key is whether rhetoric wrongly understood and thus wrongly taught is not a virtuous art but a knack—a series of devices, artifices and tricks that its propagators could describe but not explain.

And this is precisely what Heinrichs has produced: a handbook of sophisms. We note that, despite the subject of the book and despite attention to definition throughout the work, Heinrichs fails to define the most important term of all—*argument*. The failure undermines his efforts to defend rhetoric or provide an especially useful manual on argumentation. Heinrichs slides back and forth through the different senses of the term. He fails to distinguish between argument as a function of rhetorical reason giving in order to convince, argument as a tool for achieving consensus, and argument as a form of proof. Indeed, Heinrichs' understanding of argument is so broad and amorphous that at one point he seems to take the position that almost anything that might modify anyone's behavior is argumentative including a wristwatch alarm, smoke detector and even a pile of fox poop.

Similarly, while leaning heavily upon Aristotelian distinctions, Heinrichs ignores Aristotle's warning in *Rhetoric* of language designed to provoke emotion such as prejudice, pity, or anger. Heinrichs consistently advocates such use, yet Aristotle in *Rhetoric* likened it to warping a carpenter's rule before using it.

While we applaud Heinrichs' efforts to revitalize an interest in classical philosophers and the connection of ancient ideas to contemporary conditions, we cannot in good conscience encourage or support that effort if it is advanced by twisting Aristotle, Cicero, Augustine and others into various manifestations of Machiavelli.

This Machiavellian approach, we argue, ultimately undermines Heinrichs' efforts. Heinrichs' preaches a "whatever works" approach to argument, which is the very assumption for which Plato condemned the sophists. As Heinrichs declared outright: "If it works, then you've won the argument" (p. 19). Thus he embraces manipulation, misleading and even deception. Plato believed rhetorical practices advocated by the sophists could never be ethical since they encouraged speakers to draw from popular belief regardless of the truth of that belief and heedless of the propensity to perpetuate falsehoods. One need only recall certain efforts to encourage a war based on false but widely held beliefs that Iraq was linked with Al Queda to see the effective of the strategy. But effective does not mean ethical. The ethical question was set aside by some sophists then and by Heinrichs now.

This should not, we believe, completely disqualify Heinrichs' efforts. There is much of value in *Thank You for Arguing* and we believe students could certainly benefit from giving it a read. We do not recommend it for entry-level courses where students are most susceptible to his "If it works, then you've won the argument" (p. 19) approach. We only recommend it as a secondary text for advanced courses where the greater emphasis is placed on works more central to the philosophical and classical sources of argumentation and rhetorical theory, and where additional readings may counter-point the "whatever works" philosophy of argument.

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